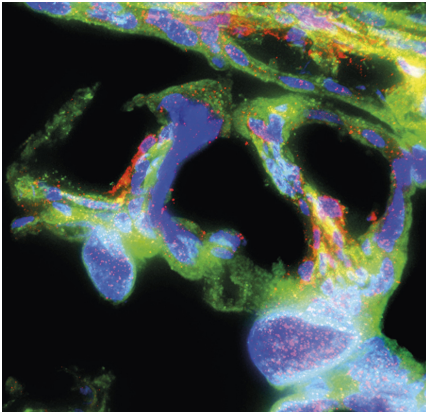




YOU ARE **3 WEEKS AND 5 DAYS**

254 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

The first stage of placental development—your baby’s life support system—is shown here. The image shows nuclei (blue) within a continuous network of cells that will become the placental villi. At first the tiny villi are solid; later, they will contain blood vessels.

“As the fertilized egg becomes completely embedded in your uterus, it may cause some light bleeding.”

The ball of cells, known as the blastocyst, that will form the embryo has now completely embedded within the lining of the uterus and the lining has regenerated over it. Only about half of all fertilized eggs progress to become a blastocyst and only about half of these successfully implant.

When the blastocyst embeds, there may be some bleeding, known as “spotting.” This can lead to confusion when dating the pregnancy as it can occur around the time that you would normally start your period. In most cases, the blood is pinkish, although bright red blood (fresh blood) can occur, as can brownish, old blood. As long as it is not profuse, the color really doesn’t matter. If the bleeding lasts for a short period, and you don’t experience discomfort, it’s likely that things are just fine, but do see your doctor for a checkup.

Around 25 percent of women will bleed in early pregnancy, but most go on to full-term. However, in some cases of bleeding, especially if there is also period-like pain, it does mean a miscarriage is occurring, so always report it to your doctor. Up to a third of pregnancies miscarry up to the fifth week and around a quarter between the fifth and seventh weeks. The risk becomes much lower as the weeks go by, decreasing dramatically after the 12th week of pregnancy.